Virna Vidal-Menezes

3060 Jenkins Nanovic Hall, Notre Dame, Indiana — vvidalme@nd.edu — www.virnavidalmenezes.com

FIELDS OF INTEREST

Development Economics, Labor Economics, and Economics of Education.

EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame, South Bend, Indiana
PhD in Economics — May 2027
MA in Economics — 2022

Federal University of Ceara, Fortaleza, CE, Brazil
MA in Economics — 2020
BA in Economics, *Magna Cum Laude* — 2017

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Looking Ahead? Future Educational Opportunities and Pre-College Human Capital"

Abstract: How do future schooling opportunities shape early educational decisions? In this paper, I exploit a large expansion in the supply of free higher education institutions (HEIs) in Brazil to analyze whether tertiary education opportunities can shift demand for secondary schooling. I construct a novel dataset on HEI rollout and combine it with rich administrative data to estimate the effect of receiving an HEI on local public-school students' secondary-school persistence using a staggered difference-in-differences design. Following the opening of a new campus, dropout rates fall in every high school grade (a 5–6% decrease from the baseline mean). As a result, students in treated municipalities are 1.5% more likely to graduate from high school, corresponding to over 20,000 additional high school graduates across the first three exposed cohorts. To understand why higher education expansion might increase persistence at lower levels, I develop a simple framework in which a new HEI can make high school more valuable either as an end, by changing local labor markets, or as a gateway to college. Testing its predictions, I find that effects are likely driven by increased college opportunities rather than by changes in the local labor market. Wages of high school graduates do not change, while local students' enrollment in federal HEIs increases by 140%. As the framework predicts, high school graduation increases only in municipalities with a high pre-policy college premium, highlighting the role of tertiary returns in raising the value of staying in school. My paper shows that expanding access to higher education can be a powerful tool for improving early educational attainment, especially in low- and middle-income countries where returns to high school alone are not enough to keep students in school.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

University of Notre Dame — South Bend, Indiana
Research Assistant to Professor Taryn Dinkelman — August 2022 – May 2026

Inter-American Development Bank — Washington, D.C.
Consultant Intern at the Research Department — June 2024 – August 2024

University of Virginia and University of Notre Dame — Kampala, Uganda
Survey Field Coordinator — May 2023 – July 2023

Research Institute for Technology and Innovation - IPTI — Aracaju, SE, Brazil
Impact Evaluation Researcher — February 2021 – July 2021

Federal University of Ceara — Fortaleza, CE, Brazil
Research Assistant to Professor Guilherme Diniz Irffi — August 2019 – July 2021

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

"Mass Schooling Increases Citizens' Political Capabilities but Does Not Strengthen Civic Engagement: New Evidence from Africa" with Taryn Dinkelman

"Determinants of Free Primary Education Laws and Policies in Africa: A New Dataset" with Taryn Dinkelman and Amadou Jawo

"The Comprehensive Impacts of a National Inclusion Policy for Students with Disabilities" with Angelo dos Santos and Ramon Lima Ribeiro

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics — South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Principles of Microeconomics. Course Evaluation: 5/5. — Summer 2026

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics — South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Introduction to Linear Regression. Course Evaluation: 5/5. — Fall 2024

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics — South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Development Data Stata Bootcamp. — Summer 2024

Getulio Vargas Foundation (FGV), School of Public Policy and Government — Brasilia, DF, Brazil
Teaching Assistant, Graduate Causal Inference for Public Policy. — Fall 2020

GRANTS AND HONORS

National Academy of Education (NAEd) and Spencer Foundation — Washington, D.C.
NAEd/Spencer Dissertation Fellowship — September 2026 – Present

Kellogg Institute for International Studies — South Bend, Indiana
Kellogg Graduate Research Grant — January 2026

Arnold Ventures — San Francisco, California
Grant to attend the "Differences-in-Differences Causal Inference Workshop" — November 2024

AFFILIATIONS

Building Inclusive Growth (BIG) Lab — South Bend, Indiana
BIG Lab Doctoral Student Affiliate — May 2023 – Present

Kellogg Institute for International Studies — South Bend, Indiana
Kellogg Doctoral Student Affiliate — February 2023 – Present

Notre Dame Program for Interdisciplinary Educational Research (PIER) — South Bend, Indiana
Notre Dame Burns Fellow — August 2021 – Present

SERVICE AND PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

Referee: *Journal of Human Resources*

Office of Grants and Fellowships, University of Notre Dame — South Bend, Indiana
Speaker on Grant and Fellowship Winners Panel — August 2026

Department of Economics, University of Notre Dame — South Bend, Indiana
Graduate Student Committee Co-chair — August 2023 – May 2024

Getulio Vargas Foundation (FGV) and Itau Social — Sao Paulo, SP, Brazil
Advanced Summer Course in Public Policy and Social Projects Evaluation — January 2020 – March 2020

PRESENTATIONS

2026 Midwest International Economic Development Conference (MWIEDC), MidSouth Education Policy Workshop, Midwest Economics of Education.
2025 Association for Public Policy and Analysis (APPAM) Fall Conference.
2024 Southern Economic Association (SEA) 94th Annual Meeting.

SKILLS AND PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- **Technical Skills:** Stata, Matlab, R, SurveyCTO, LaTeX.
- **Language Skills:** Portuguese (native), English (fluent), French (advanced), and Spanish (advanced).
- **Professional Memberships:** Association for Public Policy and Analysis (APPAM), American Economic Association (AEA), Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP), American Educational Research Association (AERA), Society for Research on Educational Effectiveness (SREE).

REFERENCES

Taryn Dinkelman
Associate Professor
Department of Economics
University of Notre Dame
Email: tdinkelm@nd.edu
Phone: (574) 631-0239

Jeff Denning
Associate Professor
School of Public Affairs
University of Texas at Austin
Email: jeffdenning@utexas.edu
Phone: (512) 471-7551

Joseph Kaboski
Professor
Department of Economics
University of Notre Dame
Email: jkaboski@nd.edu
Phone: (574) 631-9906

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